

CHAPTER 3 BUILDING PLANNING

SECTION R311.7.10.1 2012 Edition IRC Interpretation 06-16 Issued 6-21-2016 RE_12_06_16

R311.7.10.1 Spiral stairways. Spiral stairways are permitted, provided the minimum clear width at and below the handrail shall be 26 inches (660 mm) with each tread having a 7½-inch (190 mm) minimum tread depth at 12 inches (914 mm) from the narrower edge. All treads shall be identical, and the rise shall be no more than 9½ inches (241 mm). A minimum headroom of 6 feet 6 inches (1982 mm) shall be provided.

REFERENCED SECTION:

SECTION R311 MEANS OF EGRESS

R311.1 Means of egress. All *dwelling*s shall be provided with a means of egress as provided in this section. The means of egress shall provide a continuous and unobstructed path of vertical and horizontal egress travel from all portions of the *dwelling* to the exterior of the *dwelling* at the required egress door without requiring travel through a garage.

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Q: Is Section R311.7.10.1 applicable to exterior spiral stairways that are not part of the required means of egress?

A: Yes.

Section R311.1 states the general intent of Section R311, which is that an unobstructed path of egress be provided from all portions of the dwelling to the required egress door. This ensures an acceptable level of safety for occupants. However, other means of egress elements located on the exterior of the dwelling including, but not limited to, spiral stairways, must also be constructed in such a manner that they serve their intended purpose without creating a hazard to the building occupants or general public.

Therefore, exterior spiral stairways must also be constructed in compliance with Section R311.7.10.1.
